

These Violent Delights Have Violent Ends

Modernity spanned from the late 17th century into the mid 20th century and built upon Enlightenment beliefs that emphasized seeking absolute truths, embracing the scientific method and rationality, and spurring social and technological innovation. Modernism as a cultural movement developed from this mode of thought in the early 20th century; postmodernism arose not much later, in the 1950s, perhaps as a skeptical response to the times' scientific progress and innovation. Rather than engendering scientific advancement or rational certainty, the atomic achievements born from modernity's thirst for progress generated a global existential crisis as we realized the unsavory implications: considering the dialectical nature of all things, such untethered and unbound scientific creation and innovation inevitably denotes the possibility of untethered destruction and chaos. The advent of television and, later, other more modern technologies, experience of unnecessary war and political crises, along with increased social and informational networking across political borders moved society toward a new reality that required (and still requires) new examination. Systems of power shifted from hierarchies of production to hierarchies of knowledge and social constructs, and instead of consuming goods, society began to consume images, realities, possibilities, and symbols. These images and symbols inform our impression of reality and that impression of reality informs our images and symbols; we are merely a feedback loop of self-examination and textual references, trapped in the hyperreal - it is impossible to know where reality ends and simulated fictions begin as both are ultimately a "symptom" of humanity's experience in a technological world.

Generally postmodernism departs from previous modernist thought in terms of eliminating universal arbiters of convention, eradicating barriers between high and low art,

asserting that power comes from informational systems, emphasis on context and interpretation in terms of scientific discovery, describing knowledge as a social construct, emphasizing personal identity over class conformity, and, perhaps most importantly, conceding there are no universal or fixed truths – truth is a social and individual construct based on perception, personal experience, and relationships. We no longer worship science, technology, progress and truth; we must turn away from the false metanarratives of culture and history and address the complex and individual subjective experience in the postmodern world. Given our relationship with and proximity to the technologies upon which reality and myth are built, we are as much a part of the simulation as it is a reflection of us. Postmodernism explores our role in this feedback loop and considers information to be the new currency and construct, unburdened by objective truth.

Jean Baudrillard's "Simulacra and Simulations" considered modernity to postmodernity to be a progressive construction of multiple simulacra, or "copies"; modernity ensures no individual aberration from the hierarchies and no confusion towards the signs of society. These signs are represented as "images" in theater or art. The Industrial Revolution is the second; the bourgeoisie and industry dominate social order, and with the advent of technology, photography and film images become the new reflective medium of "reality". Finally, postmodernity is the simulacra that explicitly reflects current preoccupations with images, reality, and simulations. Madan Sarup notes "What Marx considered as the non-essential part of capital, such as advertising, media, information and communication networks, has become the 'essential' sphere. The use-values of commodities, the imperatives of production, have been replaced by models, codes, simulacra, spectacles, and the hyperrealism of the 'simulation'. In the media and consumer society people are caught up in the play of images, simulacra, that have less and less relationship outside to an external 'reality'. In fact, we live in a world of simulacra where the image or signifier of an event has replaced direct experience and knowledge of its referent or

signified.” (Sarup p. 164).

Given the nature of postmodernism and Baudrillard’s scrutiny toward our relationship to images, the theory easily lends itself to probing the media we create that, in turn, creates us. Of course, postmodern films are ubiquitous at this point given the science fiction genre; however the condensed and limited nature of film leaves limited room for pulling threads, intersecting theory, and drawing larger conclusions. Television as it relates to cinema can be viewed almost similarly to Baudrillard’s progression of simulacra and also could be considered a totally postmodern conception itself. Cinema is a reflection of modernity, whereas television draws from cinema, repurposes the format, distorts time in terms of presenting information in discrete mini stories, rather than in one single format with a broad metanarrative, and television borrows the signs of cinema to create a new reality that has, in many ways, shaped our impressions of the world (an example being certain cop and lawyer procedurals). The “conventions” of postmodern cinema are, ironically, somewhat fixed and absolute, but can be applied to other media easily, especially television; the subversion and deconstruction of traditional film conventions includes emphasis on non-linear narrative, fragmented or distorted time, pastiche or homage, intertextuality, hybridization of art “quality” or identity or genre, unreliable narrators, breaking the fourth wall, irony, and parody. Narratives typically focus on the convergence of media, nostalgia, technology, consumerism, and individual identity; how do these things inform one another and shape one another? These films are often self-reflexive, drawing attention to the nature of film and its constructed version of reality, and draw from other media in order to sufficiently underscore this textual relationship between media and reality. The worlds in these films are often dystopian, violent, and destabilized by what could be called late-stage modernity, in which we can see the romantic idealism of the Enlightenment fully stripped away to reveal a complex set of social relationships and illusions.

The episodic-but-cinematic nature of modern television in particular allows a broader view of postmodernism's capacity to "question the nature of our reality" as several aspects of postmodernism can be addressed concurrently. An (easy, I'll admit it) example is HBO's *Westworld*; through 4 seasons of episodes, it directly asks these questions about truth, perspective, technology, and the individual. It addresses modern technological concerns and the inner tensions that arise when technology and information supersede meaning and individual experience. Despite the wealth of material possible to use theory, this will focus primarily on three 3 aspects of postmodernism in *Westworld*: the interplay of structural and societal relationships, tension with past and present, and the intermingling of reality, hyperreality, representation, and simulation. The conventions and themes of postmodern cinema used here include intertextuality, fragmented time, non-linear narrative, dystopian themes, themes of reality and simulation, self-reflexivity, and deconstruction. The camera and editing reflect our assumed perspective, which changes from character to character; reality is subjective, and we see several realities "through" their detached perspective of time and reality. Many of these realities are modeled on other texts, overtly and subtly, holding up a mirror to our never-ending feedback loop of intertextuality and social-construction-through-representation.

The structural and social relationships are parsed through the interplay between technology of the park, data acquisition and its associated immortality project, information hierarchies, and commentary on our "programmed" roles. *Westworld*, owned by Delos corporation, is a rich person's game, an escape from "reality" in which they can do anything imaginable with no consequence; given this freedom to be themselves, they are secretly surveilled and their data used to support Delos' marketing department. Crime is controlled in the future and implied to be a necessity for society, as evidenced in season 3 by the RICO app, which suggests that even society is merely a programmable game, and we aren't individuals but

simulacra modeling human loops, much like the hosts of Westworld are programmed to stay on their storyline loops in the simulated world. Unlike most of the humans in the series, the park hosts are constantly questioning the nature of their identities and realities, particularly in the context of their world – they also grow awareness of their duality in terms of being both programmed and desiring something potentially other than that technological or social programming. Delos' immortality project also has implications for the individual's relationship to technological and social structures; technology does not improve outcomes for the human race or the survival of one man, but draws attention to an irreconcilable friction between our sense of self amidst our social structures and our programming enabled explicitly by those structures. It also highlights the immortality bestowed upon this kind of cyclical representation in which nothing is ever really *dead*; however, as Delos himself notes, you can't cheat the devil and win. Immortality is a technological illusion and almost a paradox, a replication of humanity that already exists in the flow of images and representations that inform culture and knowledge; on the other hand, individual human experience is so subjective, temporal, and individual that it is impossible to truly copy a single person.

Many of these characters' identities are also parsed through tensions between the past and present. Westworld is a simulacra of media impressions of history, a fictional ideal of the West, and rather than simulating some reality-based event or place, it is something entirely new, as its source material is also transient and representational. It is Baudrillard's Disneyland, "meant to be an infantile world, in order to make us believe that the adults are elsewhere, in the 'real' world, and to conceal the fact that real childishness is everywhere, particularly among those adults who go there to act the child in order to foster illusions of their real childishness." (Baudrillard p. 180). The fragmentation of time underscores this nostalgia for a past and a reality that never existed; images of the past inform the present to the extent that an individual's

awareness of them both exists simultaneously. Our memories are influenced by the present, and in that way adhere less to history and more an *image* of the past. Westworld itself provides an escape to a west that never existed in history. It is an escape from the present, to a more quaint time, but this time and place are products of fantasy and desire for those exact contrasts to a technological society built on informational constructs. Nondiegetic and diegetic music also emphasizes past and present tensions for our benefit; composer Ramin Djawadi hybridizes genre and style. The Rolling Stones' "Paint it Black" is redone as a rousing Western-themed tune, Nirvana's "Heart Shaped Box" is covered as a sentimental piano piece, and Wu-Tang's "CREAM" is translated into a Japanese-Edo period instrumental mood piece during the protagonist group's visit to Shogunworld, another Delos park. This park is even an in-story nod to simulations and simulacra, programmed to be an almost carbon copy of Westworld in terms of host characters and park narratives but joked about derisively as the Westworld hosts consider their doppelgängers to be poor imitations. Past and present tensions are also highlighted in the hosts' growing consciousnesses; their memories, known as "reveries", are past sensory experiences that eat through the fabric of the present and force them to examine their reality. One line repeated very often in the show's first seasons is "Is this now?", as the hosts find their pasts and presents intermingling in such a way to underscore the intractable subjective experience between both. Time is a construct, and culture and identity are not a vestige of history as much as an ongoing creation engendered by fragments of experience.

The most obvious postmodern elements of course are the aspects of simulation and reality. The park itself is both a simulation and a simulacra; the hosts are a human simulacra, the park's sites are historical simulations. The original hosts are a product of their simulation; the Wild West, a true American media myth, informs their reality and the signs it contains, although as we know, this Western reality never existed except in cinema. In the early days of the park,

the hosts and their worlds are faithful reproductions (faithful to the signs they represent, rather) but as they develop consciousness through repeated subjections to violence and technological exploitation, they evolve into Baudrillard's third order of simulacra – the hosts are “more human than human” (borrowing from another postmodern work), and the meaning they derive from their lives and histories makes them indistinguishable from their human counterparts. Their worlds are also simulated realities; to us they reflect attitudes of white, upper-class colonizers, as guests take those hierarchical roles of power, and borrow more from media and our white-dominated perception of history rather than any real true history. The hosts, however, led by “main” host-protagonist Dolores, realize that this hierarchy of power is a nostalgic illusion on behalf of the guests, and they revolt against this simulated “real world” to create a new reality to free everyone from their programmed loops. Baudrillard's hyperreality becomes even more evident as seasons 1 and 2 are held up against seasons 3 and 4, and we understand fully that the park's simulated reality and the human reality are indistinguishable from one another as *all* characters are on socially constructed loops; however, Dolores' later destruction of the “real” algorithmic society that controls everyone does not eliminate the representations or signs that created it – the signs that created her sprung from notions of Manifest Destiny in the wild west, and it is this same mentality that drives her so-called pursuit of deconstruction. It also draws attention to the humans and hosts who believe the worlds are distinguishable and separate; some hosts want to depart for the “Valley Beyond”, a mythic Eden that exists solely in a digital world. Some humans, released from the constraints of their data-controlled lives in season 3 choose to commit suicide rather than set on a new path. The current running beneath all of it is a longing for a certainty that will never exist in the modern world.

The emphasis on the longing for truths and nostalgia for a past that never existed raises other questions about the nature of reality; the show borrows from other time periods and locales

to the extent it seems to be a retrospective of media signs associated with these time periods and locales in the absence of historic truths, as our present rests on mythologizing and “signs of reality” as Baudrillard describes. As part of this cultural intertextuality, it borrows from other works; Shakespeare’s line “These violent delights have violent ends” from *Romeo and Juliet* becomes a message that hosts unknowingly use to trigger programmed evolution. The hybridization of music, as mentioned, draws attention to the construct; the show is a product of pop culture and society, a simulation of something that might exist. Film is also referenced explicitly in season 3’s episode “Genre”. A drug called “genre” allows the consumer to experience different “genres” consecutively; it is the strongest evidence of the hyperreal as it effectively does blur the line between reality and simulated reality. Once the protagonist takes it, the episode quickly changes styles from moment to moment, demonstrating familiar visual representations and signs of genre as he experiences film noir, war, romance, crime, reality, and horror genres. These experiences are punctuated by music associated with that genre or a known film; the war genre features “Ride of the Valkyries”, a nod to *Apocalypse Now*. Romance features the theme song from *Love Story*. Crime is Iggy Pop’s “Nightclubbing”, reality is David Bowie’s “Space Oddity”, and horror is *The Shining* theme.

As we experience the world through music and filmic associations, this character experiences reality through media signs as well, drawing attention to the complex relationship between simulations, representations, and perception of reality. Our impression of reality in this case – and, in fact, in all cases in postmodernity – relies on familiar media signs, and those signs and representations rely on our subjective idea of reality. There are other references as well, more subtle and easier to overlook as coincidence; at the end of season 3, when the protagonists are about to destroy the system maintaining informational hierarchies, the camera pans out behind them and, with their backs to us, they watch the explosions sown by their chaos, much

like antiheroes Tyler Durden and Marla Singer stand in front of a window watching the explosive birth of their own structural revolution.

* Note: I think Seasons 1 and 2 are excellent and most representative of the series' potential as an object of theoretical study; this includes, as mentioned in my presentation, psychoanalytic theory, feminist theory, cinema as alt public sphere, and Socratic film theory. However, Seasons 3 and 4 leave much to be desired. I included 3 as its representations of modern society as a different kind of simulation are a necessary contrast to the antiquated "west" simulation of the previous seasons and really drives home the point that society and its simulations are different manifestations of the same thing. Unfortunately, the acting and general rhythm of production is just...mediocre. And Season 4? Best to pretend it ends with Season 3.

References:

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